

*The Complex Legacy of Gandhi's Nonviolence Policy:
A Diplomatic and Political Analysis of Its Impact on Indian Independence,
Political Discourse, and the Assassination by Nathuram Godse*

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Abstract

This thesis examines the assassination of Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi through a political lens, moving beyond moral binaries to explore the broader historical and ideological forces at play. It investigates the motivations of Nathuram Godse, the sociopolitical tensions of post-Partition India, and the long-term diplomatic and political repercussions of Gandhi's death. Drawing on primary sources including trial transcripts and contemporary media, as well as secondary scholarship, the project traces how Gandhi's assassination redefined political narratives, both domestically and globally. This work challenges idealized portrayals of Gandhi, and interrogates whether his assassination enabled a stronger state consolidation than his pluralistic ideals would have permitted, a question with enduring resonance in India's postcolonial trajectory. It aims to contribute a layered understanding of political violence and its aftershocks on democratic development in newly independent India.

Executive Summary

This project investigates the immediate and long-term consequences of Gandhi's assassination for the political, communal, and diplomatic development of newly independent India. The study is grounded in the premise that Gandhi's death represented not only the loss of a national leader but the collapse of a symbolic bridge between communities, ideologies, and competing visions of India's future.

The research is structured around three central areas of impact. It examines the Indian government's political response, including the reaffirmation of secular state principles under Nehru and the reorganization of authority within the Congress Party. It also analyzes Hindu-Muslim relations in the fragile post-Partition environment, exploring whether Gandhi's assassination heightened communal anxieties. The project studies the diplomatic ramifications, especially for India-Pakistan relations, international perceptions of India's stability, and India's emerging nonaligned foreign policy posture.

Methodologically, the thesis draws on a combination of primary sources: trial documents, parliamentary addresses, and press coverage from 1948, and secondary scholarship on Partition, early Indian state-building, and postcolonial diplomacy. By situating Godse's motives alongside the state's reaction and international responses, the project aims to show how Gandhi's assassination served as a hinge moment in determining the ideological foundations and geopolitical orientation of postcolonial India.

Rather than treating Gandhi's death as a moral tragedy alone, this project approaches it as a strategic and understudied inflection point in India's political development.

This thesis reframes Gandhi's assassination not as a moment of national rupture alone, but as a strategic political inflection point that accelerated the consolidation of a modern Indian state under Nehru's vision, precisely by removing Gandhi's ideological friction from the equation.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

Assassinations shape nations. Gandhi's death in January 1948 was not merely a moment of national mourning, it was a strategic rupture that catalyzed foundational shifts in India's postcolonial trajectory. Long mythologized as a moral loss, the assassination is reinterpreted here as a political inflection point that accelerated the consolidation of state power, redefined Hindu-Muslim relations, and recast India's international orientation under Jawaharlal Nehru.

This inquiry is guided by four interrelated questions: What ideological conflicts culminated in Gandhi's death? How did the Indian state respond, and what were the implications for Hindu-Muslim dynamics in the fragile aftermath of Partition? In what ways did the assassination shape India's diplomatic posture amid a nascent global order? And to what extent did Gandhi's absence enable the unchallenged rise of a Nehruvian model of secular governance?

While much of the existing scholarship, along with broader historical memory and public discourse, has approached Gandhi's assassination primarily as a moral tragedy and symbolic moment of communal rupture, this thesis foregrounds its political, institutional, and international consequences (Khan, 2011). Methodologically, it draws on a historical-political framework that integrates some primary documents like courtroom records from Godse's trial, Nehru's speeches, alongside scholarly interpretations of Partition, state formation, and postcolonial diplomacy.

A note on positionality: this thesis is written by an Indian student whose engagement with this subject began not in an archive but in a theater. Encountering the play *Mee*

Nathuram Godse Boltoy – long banned in Maharashtra and only recently reaching mainstream audiences – raised a question that no available historical account seemed to answer directly: why does Gandhi's assassination remain a live political argument in contemporary India, and not merely a closed historical verdict? That question, rather than any ideological commitment, drives this inquiry. The question carries particular urgency in the present. As Jaffrelot (2021) documents, the ascendance of Hindu nationalism under the BJP since 2014 has produced a systematic rehabilitation of Hindutva ideological figures and a corresponding delegitimization of Gandhian pluralism as historical weakness. Godse's political reasoning – long treated as a closed moral verdict – has re-entered public discourse as a live ideological resource. This thesis therefore engages not only with the past but with a live political contest over whose version of 1948 shapes the present. The analysis that follows attempts to examine the assassination and its consequences with analytical distance, while acknowledging that no researcher approaches a subject of this political and cultural weight from a position of complete neutrality. Where the argument risks being read as normative, the intention is strictly analytical – to understand what happened and why, not to assign blame or rehabilitate any actor.

This multidimensional approach enables a reassessment of Gandhi's assassination not as a rupture alone, but as a formative act in the making of modern India, where ideology, violence, and statecraft collided to forge a new national order.

This thesis does not argue that Gandhi's assassination was necessary for the consolidation of the Indian state, nor that the trajectory of postcolonial governance depended structurally on his death. Rather, it contends that the assassination functioned as an *accelerant* and *legitimizing rupture* within a political landscape already under strain. Institutional consolidation, secular governance, and diplomatic positioning were underway prior to

January 1948; Gandhi's death did not create these forces, but it altered the conditions under which they could be asserted, normalized, and defended. Distinguishing between causation, acceleration, and symbolic legitimation is essential to understanding how a moral catastrophe could nonetheless produce enduring political consequences.

The analysis that follows treats January 1948 not as a moment that determined India's political future, but as one that reordered the balance between moral authority, institutional power, and political legitimacy within an already unstable postcolonial landscape.

Chapter 2

Contextual Foundations: India at the Crossroads (1947-1948)

By early 1948, the newly independent Indian state stood at a precarious crossroads. Barely five months after achieving independence from British rule, the country was wracked by the psychological, political, and humanitarian fallout of Partition. Over one million lives had been lost, 10-15 million people displaced, and communal tensions simmered in Delhi, Punjab, Bengal, and other border regions (*India Partition: Red Cross Response to the Refugee Crisis*, n.d.). The state apparatus was overburdened and ill-equipped to handle the refugee crisis and escalating violence (Singh & Singh, 2025). The very notion of Indian unity, across religion, language, and region, appeared dangerously fragile.

At the heart of this moment stood Gandhi, whose continued public presence functioned as both a moral compass and a lightning rod. While formal political power had shifted to Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and his Cabinet, Gandhi still embodied the nation's ethical conscience. He traveled between riot-hit neighborhoods, met with local religious leaders, and undertook fasts to force reflection and reconciliation.

a. A Divided National Psyche

India in early 1948 was governed by multiple, competing visions. Gandhi advocated for a spiritually rooted and inclusive nationalism grounded in personal ethics, reconciliation, and voluntary self-sacrifice. Nehru, in contrast, focused on institutional modernization, economic planning, and a secular state structure modeled after European democratic socialism. Meanwhile, Hindu nationalist voices, particularly those from the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and affiliated organizations, envisioned India as a Hindu homeland, mirroring Pakistan's Islamic identity (Frayer, 2019). They perceived Gandhi's

repeated gestures toward Muslim inclusion, and his insistence on releasing funds to Pakistan, as not just naïve, but actively harmful to Hindu interests.

Hindu majoritarianism, as a political concept, refers to the assertion that India's national identity is rooted in Hindu cultural and demographic primacy, and that political authority should reflect this majority status. Critically, however, 'Hindu' was never a monolithic category. Hindu society in 1947 was deeply fractured along caste lines, with Brahmin upper castes, lower OBC communities, and Dalits holding fundamentally different relationships to political power, land, and social recognition. When critics accused Gandhi of appeasement, the question of which Hindus felt injured demands scrutiny. Upper-caste Brahmin nationalists like Godse operated from a position of social privilege, while Dalit communities under Ambedkar's leadership articulated an entirely different set of grievances, including Gandhi's opposition to separate electorates and his insistence on the term 'Harijan' rather than Dalit. The majoritarian nationalism that produced Godse's reasoning was therefore not the voice of all Hindus. It was a specific, upper-caste political project that claimed to speak for an entire community whose internal divisions it simultaneously obscured (Jaffrelot, 2021; Chatterji, Hansen and Jaffrelot, 2019).

The political landscape of 1947-48 also included a Muslim critique that further complicates the appeasement narrative. The Muslim League under Jinnah had argued consistently that the Indian National Congress, despite its secular self-presentation, was effectively a Hindu political organization whose secularism masked Hindu demographic dominance (Jalal, 1985). From this vantage point, Gandhi's appeal to Hindu-Muslim unity was not appeasement of Muslims but an assertion of Congress's right to speak for all Indians - a claim the League rejected as itself a form of Hindu cultural imperialism. This means Godse's 'appeasement' charge and the League's 'Hindu Congress' charge were mirror-image accusations, both exposing the impossibility of Gandhi's position as a figure claiming to

transcend communal politics in a landscape already structured by it (Jalal, 1985; Chatterji, Hansen and Jaffrelot, 2019).

As Gandhi wrote on the eve of his final fast:

“There is apparent calm brought about by prompt military and police action. But there is storm within the breast. It may burst forth any day... I yearn for heart friendship between the Hindus, the Sikhs and the Muslims. It subsisted between them the other day. Today it is non-existent. It is a state that no Indian patriot worthy of the name can contemplate with equanimity” (Gandhi, 1948, p. 523).

Gandhi’s framing here is deeply revealing. He positions himself as the last bulwark against the emotional and spiritual fragmentation of India. His fast, he insists, is not coercive, but a final appeal to conscience: “Let my fast quicken conscience, not deaden it. Just contemplate the rot that has set in beloved India...” (Gandhi, 1948, p. 523). In this framing, moral leadership, not statecraft, was the foundation for national survival.

Yet the critics of Gandhi's moral framework were not a single, unified voice, and understanding who felt aggrieved, and why, matters analytically. Upper-caste Hindu nationalist figures like Godse, rooted in the Brahmin community of Maharashtra, objected to Gandhi's perceived prioritization of Muslim interests over Hindu security in the aftermath of Partition. Dalit communities, however, led by B.R. Ambedkar, held an entirely different set of grievances. Ambedkar had clashed directly with Gandhi over the Poona Pact of 1932, in which Gandhi's fast unto death pressured Ambedkar into abandoning separate electorates for Dalits, a concession Ambedkar later described as coercive, arguing that joint electorates allowed upper-caste Hindus to retain effective control over Dalit political representation (Ambedkar, 1945). For Ambedkar, Gandhi's insistence on Hindu unity was itself a form of erasure, one that subordinated Dalit political autonomy to the interests of caste Hindu society.

The 'Hindu majority' that critics claimed Gandhi was failing to protect was therefore deeply fractured: Brahmin nationalists feared Muslim political power, while Dalits feared upper-caste Hindu dominance. These were not the same grievance, and collapsing them into a single critique obscures the caste hierarchies that structured Indian political life in 1947 and 1948 (Jaffrelot, 2005).

These critiques mattered not only because they came from the Hindu right, but because a parallel disillusionment also emerged among secular nationalists who feared that moral appeals were substituting for state capacity at the worst possible moment. In the months after Partition, when legitimacy depended on restoring order and protecting displaced citizens, Gandhi's interventions were increasingly read through a security lens: restraint looked like weakness, ethical symmetry looked like political imbalance, and conscience-driven pressure on the government looked like extra-constitutional coercion. The point is not to endorse the language of "appeasement," but to note how quickly it became a persuasive political category in 1947-48, one that allowed Gandhi's actions to be reframed by critics as strategically irresponsible rather than ethically consistent. That reframing is essential to understanding how opposition to Gandhi could harden from disagreement into a logic of necessity, which Godse would later formalize into a political justification for violence.

b. The Politics of Gandhi's Final Fast

The January 1948 fast was triggered not by a single incident but by a growing sense of spiritual exhaustion and political impotence. Gandhi believed he had no other tool left to awaken the conscience of the nation. In his own words:

“A pure fast, like duty, is its own reward. I do not embark upon it for the sake of the result it may bring. I do so because I must... Death for me would be a glorious

deliverance rather than that I should be a helpless witness of the destruction of India, Hinduism, Sikhism and Islam” (Gandhi, 1948, p. 523).

Here, Gandhi views the survival of all three faiths as interconnected. Yet, in asserting that Hinduism and Sikhism “have no world outside India,” he also implicitly critiques the exclusivist logic of Pakistan’s formation. He feared that India, in attempting to mirror Pakistan’s religious nationalism, would lose its civilizational uniqueness and moral authority.

To Gandhi, sovereignty was not merely about territorial integrity, but about ethical legitimacy. As he put it: “The reward will be the regaining of India’s dwindling prestige and her fast fading sovereignty over the heart of Asia and there through the world” (Gandhi, 1948, p. 523).

c. Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and the Pragmatics of State-Building

While Gandhi offered a moral vision, it was Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel who shouldered the burden of consolidating the Indian state in practical terms. As Deputy Prime Minister and Home Minister, Patel was responsible for integrating princely states, enforcing law and order, and countering both Hindu and Muslim communal militancy.

In private correspondence from this period, Patel expressed deep frustration with Gandhi’s stance. In a letter from January 1948, he acknowledged the symbolic value of Gandhi’s fast but questioned its political effects. Patel believed that too much moral pressure on the majority community, especially after the trauma of Partition, could alienate them from the Congress and weaken the government’s credibility (Patel, 1973).

He wrote that while Gandhi’s ideals were noble, “sentiment alone cannot build a state,” and warned that law and order must be upheld without bias, but also without appeasement. Patel’s correspondence also reflects a broader anxiety about national unity,

especially as secessionist movements and princely state resistance remained potent threats in Hyderabad, Junagadh, and Kashmir.

d. Reconstructing the Fragile Center

Ultimately, the first months of 1948 were marked by a dual movement: Gandhi's moral protests aimed at healing the soul of India, and Patel and Nehru's efforts to consolidate its political machinery. Nehru adopted many of Gandhi's rhetorical appeals but remained committed to building a centralized, secular, and technocratic state. In many ways, Gandhi's assassination weeks later would clear the ideological path for Nehru's vision to dominate.

Still, this period revealed deep contradictions. The Indian state sought to assert its secular foundations while operating in a communal landscape. It championed unity while its founding figures disagreed on how that unity should be forged: through law, love, or loyalty. These contradictions would not resolve in 1948, but they would crystallize. The crystallization of these tensions did not prescribe a singular political outcome, but it narrowed the space within which competing visions of authority, unity, and legitimacy could operate.

Chapter 3

Godse's Motivation: A Political Analysis

By early 1948, the moral authority Mahatma Gandhi had exercised over Indian public life for decades had become increasingly contested. In the aftermath of Partition, as communal violence, displacement, and political uncertainty gripped the newly independent state, Gandhi's continued interventions, through fasting, public appeals, and moral pressure were no longer universally interpreted as stabilizing acts. For some, they represented ethical leadership in a moment of national fracture. For others, particularly within Hindu nationalist circles, they symbolized political imbalance, strategic naïveté, and a refusal to prioritize Hindu security in an increasingly hostile environment.

It was within this charged political atmosphere that Nathuram Godse articulated the reasoning that would culminate in Gandhi's assassination. Godse's writings, composed during his trial and later published as *Why I Killed Gandhi*, do not present themselves as confessions of personal grievance or emotional rupture. Instead, they unfold as a structured political argument, aimed at explaining why Gandhi's influence had, in Godse's view, become incompatible with the survival of the Indian nation (Godse, 2024, pp. 15-18). Gandhi is not attacked as a personal enemy or moral hypocrite; he is recast as a political liability whose authority obstructed what Godse understood to be necessary acts of sovereign governance.

That such reasoning culminated in assassination reflects not an unavoidable political logic, but the extreme contraction of political imagination under conditions of fear, grievance, and ideological absolutism.

a. Partition and the Moralization of Political Grievance

Godse grounds his political worldview in the violence and displacement of Partition, which he presents not as a shared national catastrophe but as a predominantly Hindu tragedy. His narrative foregrounds refugee suffering, communal massacres, and the perceived failure of the Indian state to protect Hindu populations, treating these experiences as evidence of a deeper moral collapse within national leadership (Godse, 2024, pp. 16-20). Partition is not framed as the outcome of imperial withdrawal or administrative breakdown; it is mobilized as proof that ethical restraint had produced material consequences for Hindu survival.

What is analytically significant is not the empirical accuracy of these claims, but their function. Partition operates in Godse's reasoning as a moral accelerator. Political disagreement is transformed into existential crisis, and compromise becomes indistinguishable from surrender. By selectively emphasizing Hindu suffering while minimizing Muslim losses or reciprocal violence, Godse constructs a zero-sum moral landscape in which restraint by the majority community appears as collective self-harm. Within this frame, Gandhi's repeated appeals for reconciliation and ethical symmetry are stripped of their universal moral meaning and reinterpreted as denial of Hindu pain.

The trial court itself noted that the motive was a political one, originating after the partition of the country, and that the accused strongly felt that had it not been for Mahatma Gandhi the country would never have been divided into the two dominions (Padmavathi & Hari Prasath, 2021, Chapter V, p. 39). Partition thus becomes the emotional and ideological foundation upon which later justifications are built. It converts grievance into urgency and establishes the conditions under which extraordinary political measures can be imagined as necessary rather than exceptional.

b. Majoritarian Nationalism and the Rejection of Pluralism

Godse's reasoning is inseparable from a majoritarian conception of the Indian nation. Drawing on the ideological traditions of the Hindu Mahasabha and early Hindu nationalist thought, he advances an understanding of India as a civilizational entity whose political legitimacy derives from Hindu cultural and demographic primacy (Godse, 2024, pp. 24-26). Scholars of comparative politics have situated this ideological tradition within a broader framework of ethnic nationalism and what Jaffrelot (2021) terms an 'ethnic democracy', a majoritarian order that equates the dominant community with the nation itself, structurally marginalizing minorities rather than incorporating them as equal citizens. In this framework, secularism is not neutrality but asymmetry, and pluralism is not inclusion but dilution.

This vision of Hindu primacy was not a cross-caste consensus; it was articulated predominantly by upper-caste nationalists, particularly from Brahmin communities in Maharashtra, whose social position and cultural authority shaped which grievances were deemed politically legitimate.

The creation of Pakistan occupies a central place in this argument. For Godse, Partition exposed what he perceived as a fundamental imbalance in Indian nationalism: Muslims were granted a religious homeland, while Hindus were expected to suppress political self-assertion in the name of coexistence. Gandhi's insistence on Hindu-Muslim unity is therefore interpreted not as moral consistency, but as ideological refusal to acknowledge this asymmetry (Godse, 2024, pp. 27-29).

Pluralism, within Godse's political logic, becomes untenable not as a general principle but in the specific context created by Partition. The creation of Pakistan is treated as a decisive rupture that redefined the terms of political legitimacy on the subcontinent. For

Godse, Muslim demands for a separate state constituted an assertion of religious sovereignty - the claim that political security and self-rule required a state governed by Muslims. Once this principle was accepted and institutionalized through Pakistan's formation, Godse argues that insisting on continued Hindu restraint and pluralist accommodation within India produced an asymmetrical and unjust political order (Godse, 2024, pp. 24-29). In this framing, Gandhi's commitment to Hindu-Muslim coexistence appears not as moral consistency but as refusal to acknowledge a transformed political reality. Democracy is therefore not rejected outright; rather, it is reconceptualized as majoritarian sovereignty grounded in post-Partition reciprocity. Ethical universalism, in Godse's view, is subordinated to political survival, as a state that denies its majority political primacy after conceding religious sovereignty elsewhere is portrayed as incapable of defending itself or asserting coherent authority.

c. Sovereignty, Security, and the ₹55 Crore Decision

Godse's critique of Gandhi sharpens around specific political episodes, most notably Gandhi's insistence that India release ₹55 crores to Pakistan in January 1948 (Pande, n.d.). Although the payment was legally mandated under the Partition agreement, Godse treats it as symbolic evidence that moral principle had overridden strategic judgment (Godse, 2024, pp. 19-21). Godse's written statement before the court confirmed this framing explicitly, describing Gandhi's fast of 13 January 1948 as having been started to coerce the Government of India to pay the sum of fifty-five crores of rupees to the Government of Pakistan (Padmavathi & Hari Prasath, 2021, Chapter V, p. 35). The payment is not analyzed as fiscal policy but as capitulation to an enemy state.

Within Godse's narrative, Pakistan is framed as an active aggressor, particularly in Kashmir. Any financial concession is therefore interpreted as materially enabling violence

against India. Gandhi's fast, which pressured the government to proceed with the payment, is recharacterized as coercive moral authority that bypassed democratic deliberation (Godse, 2024, pp. 21-23). What Gandhi understood as ethical persuasion is reframed as illegitimate interference in sovereign decision-making.

Godse repeatedly contrasts Gandhi with Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, whom he associates with pragmatism, institutional authority, and security-oriented governance. This contrast allows Godse to present his opposition not as anti-state rebellion but as defense of sovereign autonomy. Gandhi's moral influence, once celebrated as a unifying force, becomes a destabilizing presence that undermines elected authority at a moment of national vulnerability.

d. The Political Rejection of Ahimsa

A central move in Godse's argument is the political rejection of Gandhian nonviolence. While acknowledging *ahimsa* as a personal ethical ideal, he repeatedly argues that it is incompatible with the realities of statecraft in a post-Partition world structured by armed conflict and territorial rivalry (Godse, 2024, pp. 22-24). Moral restraint is reframed as strategic weakness rather than virtue.

This rejection is framed not as cynicism, but as realism. Godse portrays nonviolence as appropriate to individual conduct but disastrous when elevated to the level of national policy. Gandhi's insistence on ethical symmetry, particularly toward Pakistan is presented as blindness to asymmetrical aggression. In this logic, moral restraint exposes the nation.

Analytically, this move is decisive. By stripping *ahimsa* of political legitimacy, Godse removes the final normative barrier to violence. Once ethical politics is dismissed as

impractical, survival becomes the sole metric of political judgment, and violence can be reimagined as necessity rather than transgression.

e. The “Climax” Logic: From Political Opposition to Moral Necessity

Part V of Godse’s text marks a clear shift from argument to declaration. Gandhi is no longer portrayed merely as misguided or politically harmful; he becomes the culmination of what Godse describes as anti-national appeasement (Godse, 2024, pp. 24-27). This framing introduces a logic of finality. Political alternatives are exhausted, patience is no longer possible, and corrective action is framed as overdue. The ‘appeasement’ charge was not a neutral description but a politically charged category that assumed Hindu interests were a unified bloc, an assumption that collapsed real caste divisions into a single majoritarian grievance narrative.

Godse emphasizes that he did not act out of personal hatred, but out of perceived national duty. Gandhi’s symbolic authority is identified as the core problem: so long as he lived, no government or policy could effectively counter what Godse viewed as appeasement, because Gandhi’s moral influence foreclosed alternative courses of action (Godse, 2024, pp. 25-28). Political opposition thus becomes structurally impossible.

It is at this point that assassination becomes intelligible within Godse’s worldview. Once Gandhi is constructed as both uniquely responsible and irreplaceable as an obstacle, violence appears not as choice but as obligation. The act is framed as tragic but unavoidable, undertaken in the belief that it would restore sovereign clarity and liberate the nation from moral paralysis.

f. Political Violence as Corrective Action

One of the most consequential aspects of Godse's reasoning is his insistence that assassination constituted a form of political correction rather than rebellion. He repeatedly claims to have acted in defense of democracy, arguing that Gandhi's fasting and moral pressure undermined constitutional processes by coercing elected leaders (Godse, 2024, pp. 21-23). In this inverted logic, the assassin assumes the role of guardian of the political order.

Murder is no longer criminal deviation; it is reframed as intervention where institutions have failed. Legitimacy derives not from legality, but from perceived necessity. Once this threshold is crossed, moral and legal boundaries collapse, and violence becomes integrated into political reasoning rather than standing outside it.

Understanding this logic does not render it persuasive or acceptable. It reveals how extremist political reasoning operates by transforming moral authority into threat, ethical restraint into weakness, and violence into civic responsibility.

While Godse's reasoning presents itself as internally coherent, it ultimately rests on a critical logical failure: the assumption that Gandhi's moral authority constituted a singular, irreplaceable obstruction to sovereign governance. This premise collapses political pluralism into personal causality. By treating Gandhi as the sole barrier to state action, Godse ignores the multiplicity of institutional actors, public opinion, and constitutional mechanisms already shaping postcolonial decision-making. The leap from moral constraint to existential threat depends not on empirical necessity but on ideological compression, reducing complex political disagreement into a personalized point of elimination. It is precisely this collapse (from contested authority to imagined singular obstruction) that transforms political grievance into justification for irreversible violence.

This chapter has traced Nathuram Godse's motivation as a political construction shaped by Partition trauma, majoritarian nationalism, and anxieties over sovereignty. By examining how Gandhi's actions were reinterpreted as existential betrayals, it demonstrates how political disagreement can be radicalized into moral certainty and how violence can come to be understood as necessary rather than exceptional.

This explanation does not legitimize Godse's conclusions or diminish the moral gravity of his act. It clarifies the mechanism through which ideological absolutism collapses complexity into necessity.

Chapter 4

The Assassination and Immediate Aftermath

Gandhi's assassination on 30 January 1948 struck India at a moment of profound fragility. The trial court record establishes that on 30 January 1948, Godse stepped out of the crowd at the Birla House prayer-ground and fired three shots at point-blank range in quick succession with Automatic Pistol No. 606824, causing injuries the medical examiner confirmed were fatal (Padmavathi & Hari Prasath, 2021, Chapter XIII, pp. 88-89). Godse waived cross-examination of all prosecution witnesses relating to the shooting, and confirmed in his own statement that he had acted with deliberate intent (Padmavathi & Hari Prasath, 2021, Chapter XIII, p. 90).

Politically, the young republic was still consolidating its administrative machinery, absorbing the shock of Partition, and navigating both communal violence and territorial conflict. Ideologically, the nation was torn between competing visions: Gandhian nonviolence, Hindu nationalist assertiveness, Ambedkarite critiques of caste, and the Congress's pragmatic state-building approach (Begum & Dehingia, 2025). As established in the previous chapter, Gandhi himself occupied an increasingly contested space within this landscape. His death, therefore, did not occur in a moment of equilibrium; it occurred at a moment when India's moral and political identity was still being negotiated.

The meaning of Gandhi's death was therefore not fixed at the moment of violence; it emerged through the political, legal, and diplomatic responses that followed, each of which reflected choices rather than foregone conclusions.

a. Nehru's Address: An Emotional Speech Delivered in the Voice of the State

Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru's radio broadcast, issued within hours of the assassination, is often remembered for its poetic grief. Yet it was also the first major crisis address delivered by the head of government of an independent India: a new state whose legitimacy was still emerging.

This duality matters. When Nehru declared that "the light has gone out of our lives and there is darkness everywhere," he was speaking not only as a grieving friend and colleague but as the constitutional voice of the Indian state (Nehru, 1948). The emotional register of the speech, unusual for a head of government addressing a national emergency, signaled to both domestic and international audiences that India's political leadership saw Gandhi not merely as a political figure but as a moral foundation of the republic.

The choice to speak emotionally rather than bureaucratically had three major consequences:

1. It framed the Indian state as a moral project rather than a purely political one.

By elevating Gandhi as "the light," Nehru associated the legitimacy of the new state with ethical principles, signaling that independent India would define itself through moral leadership rather than imperial realpolitik. This move aligned seamlessly with Gandhi's global reputation and signaled continuity rather than rupture.

2. It shaped global perceptions of India's diplomatic identity.

Foreign correspondents broadcast Nehru's speech worldwide within hours. For many international observers, especially in the West, this was the first direct exposure to the voice of independent India's prime minister. The emotional, dignified, and morally charged tone helped cement India's early image as a peace-oriented nation, a civilizational democracy, and

a moral force in global politics. This was not trivial because it strengthened Nehru's later ability to argue for nonalignment not as strategic fence-sitting but as an ethical position. It positioned India as a nation whose political crises and responses were rooted in principle, not opportunism.

3. It enabled the government to act firmly while appearing morally restrained.

Nehru's emotional condemnation of the "poison... spread in this country" provided a rhetorical platform for decisive action against the RSS and Hindu Mahasabha (The Hindu, 2015). The people remained divided on whether the government's crackdown on the RSS and Hindu Mahasabha reflected an objective assessment of their culpability or a politically necessary moment of ideological boundary-setting for the new republic. What is clear, however, is that Nehru's emotional framing, like his references to "poison" and appeals to unity, created the rhetorical conditions in which decisive state action could be publicly justified without appearing vindictive or partisan. In this sense, the question of "fairness" becomes less important than the political function the crackdown served: it allowed the government to define the moral perimeter of postcolonial citizenship and to reassure international observers that India would confront extremist nationalism with constitutional resolve rather than authoritarian repression. In diplomatic terms, this allowed India to respond forcefully to domestic extremism, maintain the image of a nonviolent and principled state, and reassure global powers that the world's largest new democracy would not descend into authoritarian reaction. The emotional tone thus provided political cover for firm state action.

b. State Action as a Diplomatic Gesture

The government's swift ban on the RSS, the large-scale arrests, and the initiation of the conspiracy trial signaled far more than an internal security response. The trial court's findings confirmed that the conspiracy to murder Gandhi had been in existence from at least

9 January 1948, involving coordinated movement across Poona, Bombay, Gwalior, and Delhi under assumed names - a finding that provided the judicial cover for a security crackdown that simultaneously served Nehru's broader project of delegitimizing Hindu nationalist opposition and consolidating secular state authority on the international stage (Padmavathi & Hari Prasath, 2021, Chapter XXV, p. 152). To foreign observers, these measures were meant to signal a declaration of the ideological boundaries of the new republic. In the aftermath of global wartime fascism, and amid widespread uncertainty about the trajectory of newly decolonized states, India's firm and legally framed action against extremist nationalism reassured international audiences that the world's largest democracy intended to defend constitutional order rather than succumb to sectarian militancy. When paired with Nehru's emotionally charged broadcast, the crackdown functioned as a diplomatic message: that India possessed both the moral seriousness and administrative will to preserve democratic stability in a region already viewed as volatile. The state's response was therefore simultaneously domestic governance and international signaling, a demonstration that India would meet political extremism with constitutional resolve rather than authoritarian excess.

c. Public Mourning as National and International Theatre

The orchestrated rituals that followed Gandhi's assassination: the immense funeral procession, the designation of a national day of prayer, and the establishment of the Gandhi National Memorial Fund, were simultaneously acts of national catharsis and diplomatic performance (Balachandran, 2024). These events unfolded under global scrutiny: foreign correspondents reported on the spectacle of mass mourning, world leaders offered public condolences, and diplomats witnessed firsthand the scale of Gandhi's symbolic power. The public rituals thus operated as a form of soft power, transforming Gandhi from a domestic moral figure into an international martyr whose death anchored India within a global

vocabulary of peace, nonviolence, and ethical leadership. The emergent canonization of Gandhi as “Father of the Nation” took on diplomatic weight as well. It positioned India not merely as another postcolonial state but as the inheritor of a civilizational moral tradition, capable of articulating an ethical framework for global politics. These mourning rituals, therefore, helped cultivate the moral authority that would later underpin India’s claims in peacekeeping, nonalignment, and anti-colonial advocacy.

d. Gandhi’s Death as a Diplomatic Turning Point

Taken together, the assassination and its aftermath constituted a pivotal moment in the formation of India’s international identity. Nehru’s emotionally resonant broadcast, delivered not as a private lament but in his official capacity as prime minister, served as a diplomatic articulation of India’s values at a moment when global audiences were watching closely. It projected the new state as principled, unified, and morally anchored, countering early anxieties that postcolonial nations might struggle to sustain democratic institutions. The government’s decisive legal actions, the rhetoric of moral responsibility, and the carefully staged national mourning converged to present India as a democracy capable of confronting extremism without abandoning its ethical commitments.

This moment of political-diplomatic reframing also reinforced the broader argument established in the preceding chapter: that the struggle to define India’s identity in the aftermath of Partition was inseparable from the state’s efforts to institutionalize Gandhi’s legacy. Gandhi’s death allowed the Nehru government to consolidate secular authority, delegitimize violent nationalism, transform Gandhi into a unifying national myth, and portray India on the global stage as a democracy grounded in moral leadership. In doing so, the assassination became not merely a national tragedy but a foundational turning point in

shaping the republic's values, its international posture, and the symbolic architecture of its early diplomacy.

Chapter 5

The Diplomatic Repercussions

Gandhi's assassination did not merely disrupt India's internal political landscape; it altered the country's position within the global imagination at a formative moment in international history. Outside India, Gandhi was not regarded primarily as a party leader or ideological figurehead, but as a moral icon whose life and methods had come to symbolize an alternative to the coercive politics of the mid-twentieth century. His death was sudden, violent, and ideologically charged and produced not only an outpouring of international sympathy but also a recalibration of how the world viewed the Indian state and Nehru recognized this opportunity immediately. In the decade that followed, India's diplomacy drew heavily on the symbolic vacuum created by Gandhi's absence, allowing the new republic to define itself as the inheritor of his moral authority at a time when global politics was polarized, militarized, and rapidly organizing itself into competing ideological blocs. Gandhi's absence thus became a strategic presence: his death offered India a powerful moral vocabulary through which to introduce itself as a non-aligned, peace-oriented, and ethically grounded actor in global affairs.

Gandhi's assassination did not operate in isolation from broader geopolitical forces. India's size, strategic location, anti-colonial timing, and the emerging bipolar order of the Cold War all shaped its early diplomatic relevance. The argument advanced here is not that Gandhi's death replaced these material factors, but that it amplified India's capacity to frame its foreign policy through a distinctive moral vocabulary. Moral capital did not substitute for strategic relevance; it enhanced India's ability to articulate autonomy without alignment and authority without coercion.

a. Gandhi's Death and the Construction of India's Moral Identity

International reactions to the assassination framed Gandhi as a loss not just to India, but to humanity (New York Times, 1948). The tributes from global leaders reflected a geopolitical moment in which ethical authority carried strategic weight. Amid the early Cold War that was dominated by nuclear anxieties, ideological rigidity, and great-power rivalry, Gandhi appeared to embody a principle of global politics that neither superpower could claim: moral consistency.

India's leadership increasingly drew upon this international reception when articulating the country's emerging diplomatic identity. By positioning themselves as custodians of Gandhi's legacy, Indian representatives could speak with a moral force disproportionate to the country's military or economic standing. In forums such as the United Nations, where legitimacy was as much rhetorical as material, invoking Gandhi allowed India to articulate positions that stood apart from both the American and Soviet spheres. This moral posture was not an abstraction; it held strategic value. It enabled India to project stability and ethical seriousness at a time when new states were often dismissed as unprepared, fragmented, or ideologically erratic.

b. Nehru's Reframing of Gandhi for International Consumption

Nehru's speeches in the months after the assassination reveal a deliberate diplomatic strategy (Firstpost, 2025). At the UN, in Commonwealth meetings, and in bilateral communications, Nehru repeatedly invoked Gandhi not simply as a national figure but as a global teacher whose life offered an alternative paradigm for world order. This rhetoric linked India's foreign policy to a moral lineage. Instead of appearing as an inexperienced state improvising its way through the diplomatic structures inherited from colonialism, India was presented as continuing a tradition of ethical reasoning that predated both the Cold War and

Western liberal internationalism. Gandhi's name also allowed India to critique global power politics without seeming ideological. When Nehru opposed military alliances, condemned nuclear weapons, or advocated for negotiated settlements in Korea, Indo-China, or the Middle East, he could do so under the cover of Gandhian principle. This softened the appearance of political defiance and made India's diplomatic stance more palatable to Western and non-Western audiences alike. Gandhi became the interpretive key: his death allowed India to speak in a register that blended morality with realpolitik.

c. Gandhi's Absence and the Ideological Foundations of Nonalignment

The Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), though formally launched in 1961, was conceptually rooted in the diplomatic posture India adopted immediately after Gandhi's assassination. Gandhi had not articulated nonalignment himself, yet his philosophy of autonomous moral action—unattached to great-power incentives—offered a powerful intellectual anchor for Nehru's articulation of the doctrine.

Gandhi's death contributed to this in three ways. It removed the one figure whose moral authority was greater than Nehru's, giving Nehru space to reinterpret Gandhian principles in a geopolitical context Gandhi had never confronted. As a result, nonalignment could be framed not merely as strategic autonomy but as a moral stance against violence, coercion, and ideological polarization—echoing Gandhi's own political vocabulary.

Gandhi's assassination gave nonalignment emotional resonance. To nations emerging from colonial domination, Gandhi's death symbolized the fragility of ethical leadership in a violent world. India's claim to carry his principles forward in global politics resonated with states seeking an ethical alternative to the logic of Cold War power blocs.

Gandhi's global reputation provided nonalignment with an immediate legitimacy that no other founding leader could have supplied. The US and USSR could not dismiss nonalignment as naïve or irresponsible without appearing to disparage Gandhi's moral philosophy. This shielded India's foreign policy from accusations of ideological opportunism.

d. Sacrifice, Soft Power, and India's Early Diplomatic Advantage

Gandhi's assassination generated a powerful narrative of moral sacrifice that shaped how India was perceived on the world stage in its formative years. Rather than relying solely on material power, India's early diplomacy increasingly operated through symbolic authority, drawing upon the ethical resonance associated with Gandhi's life and death. This moral symbolism provided the new republic with a distinctive form of influence, allowing it to articulate positions on peace, justice, and restraint as principled expressions of its national identity.

In this sense, Gandhi's legacy functioned as a form of soft power that enhanced India's diplomatic reach beyond what its economic or military capacity alone would have permitted. By embedding its international engagement within a moral framework rooted in Gandhian ideals, India was able to project itself as an ethical and independent actor in a polarized global environment, strengthening its credibility across ideological divides.

e. The Diplomatic Rewriting of Gandhi's Legacy

Gandhi's assassination created the conditions for a selective diplomatic reconstruction of his legacy. Internationally, the complexities of Gandhi's political career, his conflicts with Ambedkar, his ambivalence about industrial modernity, his often-conservative social positions, faded into the background. In their place emerged a distilled moral symbol: Gandhi

as an avatar of peace, justice, and moral courage. Indian diplomacy leaned into this simplified image, recognizing its power on the world stage.

This rewriting was not deception; it was strategy. By emphasizing particular aspects of Gandhi's philosophy: nonviolence, moral clarity, anti-imperial resolve, Nehru and his diplomatic corps could articulate foreign policy positions that carried a weight independent of India's material capabilities. Gandhi's death thus enabled a form of moral statecraft that shaped India's image and influence throughout the 1950s and early 1960s.

Gandhi's assassination reshaped the diplomatic landscape on which India made its first foreign policy interventions. His death created a profound symbolic resource that Nehru used deftly to construct India's identity as an ethical, independent, and peace-oriented actor amid the fractures of the Cold War. By invoking Gandhi's legacy in international forums, by positioning India as the custodian of his moral vision, and by aligning nonalignment with his philosophical inheritance, the Nehru government transformed a national tragedy into a foundation for global leadership.

In this way, the diplomatic repercussions of Gandhi's assassination were not peripheral to India's early foreign policy, they were central to the construction of India's role in the world. They allowed India to emerge not merely as a new state but as a moral presence, capable of articulating a distinctive vision of international order rooted in the legacy of its most iconic leader.

Chapter 6

Nehru's Decisions: Strengths and Failures

After Gandhi's assassination, Jawaharlal Nehru became the undisputed leader of the Indian state, but not an unshaken one. Gandhi's absence removed a powerful moral presence that had often constrained political decision-making through fasting, moral pressure, and public confrontation. At the same time, it deprived Nehru of a figure who had long functioned as an ethical interlocutor, one who challenged not only policy choices but the moral assumptions underlying them. The period that followed thus revealed both Nehru's administrative strengths and his growing vulnerabilities. While Gandhi's death allowed the state to act more decisively, it also exposed the limits of Nehru's judgment when governing without Gandhi's moral friction and restraint.

a. Freedom and Disorientation Without Gandhi

Even before January 1948, Nehru was prime minister and the central figure in government. Yet Gandhi's continued presence meant that political decisions were rarely insulated from moral challenge. Gandhi intervened publicly, used fasting as leverage, and repeatedly reminded political leaders that power carried ethical obligations beyond efficiency, legality, or national interest.

After Gandhi's death, this constraint disappeared. Nehru was no longer required to negotiate with a moral authority outside the state. In practical terms, this allowed for quicker decision-making. The government asserted constitutional authority and projected control at a moment when the survival of the republic appeared uncertain. In this narrow sense, Gandhi's absence strengthened executive capacity.

Yet this freedom also produced disorientation. Gandhi had not merely constrained Nehru; he had unsettled him. He had forced Nehru to defend, revise, or rethink his assumptions. Without that challenge, Nehru's authority became more insulated, and his vision increasingly defined the boundaries of acceptable political thought. What appeared as decisiveness was also a loss of internal correction.

Gandhi's absence did not merely create space for Nehru's authority; it presented a set of political choices about how that authority would be exercised. Nehru could have institutionalized mechanisms for moral dissent, broadened deliberative engagement with non-Congress traditions, or preserved channels for ethical contestation beyond the executive. Instead, consolidation proceeded through legal authority, administrative rationality, and symbolic reverence for Gandhi that did not translate into institutional pluralism.

The consolidation of authority that followed Gandhi's assassination should thus be understood as contingent upon political decisions taken in his absence, not as an automatic consequence of his removal from the public sphere.

b. Secularism as Order and Avoidance

Nehru's commitment to secularism hardened into doctrine after 1948 (Ansari, 2016). The state rejected religious nationalism and emphasized constitutional equality, positioning India as a plural democracy in contrast to Pakistan's Islamic identity (Ansari, 2016). In the immediate aftermath of Gandhi's assassination, secularism also functioned as a stabilizing response to political violence.

However, Nehruvian secularism was primarily legal and institutional rather than dialogical. Religion was to be managed through law and regulation, not engaged through moral debate. This approach reduced the visibility of communal politics, but it did not resolve

the cultural anxieties that had fueled them. Instead, those anxieties were treated as threats to order rather than political problems requiring sustained engagement.

Gandhi's pluralism had operated differently. It was relational, moral, and often uncomfortable. Gandhi confronted religious identity directly and demanded ethical self-restraint, especially from the Hindu majority. Nehru's secularism avoided such confrontation. In replacing moral engagement with legal closure, Nehru stabilized the state while narrowing the space for ethical negotiation.

c. Suppressing Alternatives

The period following Gandhi's assassination witnessed a gradual narrowing of the ideological space within which political alternatives could operate. Rather than serving as arenas of sustained public debate, competing visions of nationalism were increasingly managed through administrative authority and legal containment. This shift reflected a broader movement away from moral contestation toward institutional consolidation.

In the absence of Gandhi's method of ethical confrontation, political dissent was less likely to be engaged through dialogue and more likely to be treated as a threat to stability. Nehru's leadership emphasized order, constitutional legitimacy, and centralized control as essential to preserving the fragile republic. While this approach succeeded in restoring immediate political calm, it also displaced deeper ideological conflicts rather than resolving them. Ideas that had once been openly contested were pushed to the margins of political life, where they persisted without meaningful engagement.

d. Technocratic Confidence and Its Blind Spots

Freed from Gandhi's moral interventions, Nehru increasingly governed through institutional expertise, centralized planning, and confidence in rational administration. His

leadership emphasized institutional modernization and confidence in centralized governance. These strategies strengthened India's administrative capacity and provided coherence during a period of uncertainty.

Yet this technocratic orientation also produced blind spots. The emphasis on centralized solutions often overlooked social complexity and the uneven realities of local governance. Political challenges were frequently approached as problems of efficiency rather than as questions requiring sustained ethical or participatory engagement. This confidence in institutional rationality fostered stability, but it also limited the scope for self-critique and adaptive policymaking.

In foreign affairs, a similar pattern emerged. Nehru's moral internationalism reflected a principled commitment to ethical leadership, yet it sometimes underestimated the persistence of power politics. His prioritization of normative vision over strategic advantage revealed the absence of a moderating voice capable of balancing moral aspiration with geopolitical calculation.

e. Moral Authority Without Moral Correction

Perhaps the most consequential effect of Gandhi's absence was the transformation of moral authority itself. Nehru inherited Gandhi's symbolic stature but not his method. Gandhi's authority rested on vulnerability, sacrifice, and moral confrontation. Nehru's authority rested on institutions, law, and executive power.

Gandhi's interventions had unsettled governance, but they had also forced political leaders to confront ethical dilemmas publicly. Nehru addressed moral questions through policy and rhetoric, but without sustained moral challenge. Ethics became centralized within the state rather than negotiated across society.

This shift made governance smoother but less self-critical. Without Gandhi's persistent disruption, Nehru's decisions faced fewer internal checks—not because they were always correct, but because fewer voices were capable of challenging them meaningfully.

Nehru's leadership after Gandhi's assassination brought order, coherence, and institutional stability to a fragile republic. Gandhi's absence allowed the state to act decisively and to consolidate authority at a moment of existential uncertainty.

Yet the same absence exposed Nehru's vulnerabilities. Without Gandhi's moral pressure, Nehru's judgment became more insulated, his secularism more administrative, and his internationalism more idealistic than strategic. Decisions that once might have been contested were instead carried forward by confidence in institutional rationality.

The question, then, is not whether Nehru governed more efficiently without Gandhi, but whether he governed more wisely. Gandhi's presence constrained Indian politics, but it also forced the state to confront its contradictions openly. In governing without that moral friction, Nehru shaped a republic that was stable and ambitious, yet one whose early misjudgments revealed the cost of leadership without ethical interruption.

Chapter 7

Reframing the Event: A Political Necessity?

By early 1948, India had achieved sovereignty but not stability. Independence had transferred authority, yet the foundations of the postcolonial state remained fragile, contested, and emotionally charged. Gandhi's assassination is rightly remembered as a moral catastrophe. However, its political consequences demand a separate line of inquiry. This chapter steps back from questions of culpability or justification to ask a narrower but more unsettling question: whether Gandhi's continued presence might have further constrained the consolidation of the Indian state, and whether his death—tragic and indefensible—removed a form of moral intervention that had become increasingly incompatible with institutional governance.

The counterfactual inquiry pursued here does not posit an alternative history so much as it exposes the fragility of the political equilibrium that existed at the moment of independence, an equilibrium that could have fractured along multiple, competing lines. It is constrained by contemporaneous evidence, including Gandhi's final writings, Cabinet correspondence, and the political dynamics of early 1948. Counterfactual reasoning here functions as an analytical tool to illuminate limits, pressures, and incompatibilities rather than to speculate on outcomes. Its purpose is to test the relationship between moral authority and institutional power, not to imagine a recoverable political path foreclosed by violence.

This chapter seeks to situate Gandhi's assassination within broader debates about moral authority, state power, and the tensions inherent in postcolonial nation-building. The purpose is not to diminish Gandhi's ethical stature, but to interrogate the political consequences of his absence.

a. Gandhi Alive: Moral Authority as Persistent Constraint

In the final months of his life, Gandhi exercised extraordinary influence without holding office or commanding institutions. His authority rested on moral pressure: fasting, public appeals, and the capacity to shame political leaders into action. This mode of intervention had been indispensable during the struggle against colonial rule, when legitimacy derived from resistance rather than administration. After independence, however, the same moral authority increasingly operated as a constraint on governance.

Gandhi's ethical framework admitted little compromise. He rejected distinctions between personal morality and statecraft, insisting that sovereignty without moral integrity was hollow. His interventions during Partition—particularly his insistence on protecting Muslims and honoring financial commitments to Pakistan—were rooted in this absolutism. Yet these actions narrowed the government's political space at a moment when public confidence in state authority was already precarious.

Had Gandhi lived, there is little reason to assume this dynamic would have softened though any counterfactual carries inherent uncertainty. His commitment to nonviolence and ethical symmetry was not situational but foundational; his final writings and actions in January 1948 suggest no indication of retreat from moral intervention. His continued presence would likely have complicated institutional decision-making, compelling leaders to publicly justify coercion at a moment when the state needed to project authority quickly and decisively. In this sense, Gandhi alive represented not opposition to the state, but a persistent moral audit of its actions, which was conducted outside constitutional mechanisms and therefore difficult to absorb, dismiss, or institutionalize.

b. Appeasement, Legitimacy, and the Limits of Moral Absolutism

One of the most persistent criticisms of Gandhi in 1947-48 concerned appeasement. To supporters, his actions preserved India's moral legitimacy. To critics, they undermined the state's ability to protect its citizens and assert authority. This was not merely a disagreement over policy, but over the nature of legitimacy itself.

Democratic governance depends not only on ethical aspiration, but on the perception that the state can enforce boundaries and maintain order. Gandhi's refusal to privilege majority sentiment (a category that, as established earlier, was fractured along caste lines, with Brahmin nationalist anxiety about Muslim political power operating entirely separately from Dalit concerns about upper-caste dominance) or political expediency complicated this task. Notably, the critics who deployed appeasement language most forcefully were operating from positions of upper-caste social privilege, not from the communities most materially exposed to communal violence in 1947-48; their grievance was political displacement, not physical vulnerability. Gandhi's moral absolutism demanded restraint from the state even when restraint risked appearing weakness.

The issue, then, is not whether Gandhi was morally correct, but whether his ethical framework could coexist with the requirements of postcolonial state-building. A sovereign state cannot permanently govern through moral exception. Gandhi's presence forced the state to operate under conditions of continual ethical exposure, without providing institutional mechanisms to resolve moral conflict.

c. Death, Deification, and the Simplification of Governance

Gandhi's assassination abruptly resolved this tension. The Indian state no longer had to negotiate with a moral authority operating beyond constitutional structures.

Decision-making became faster, authority more centralized, and dissent more easily categorized as political rather than ethical.

This transformation did not require the abandonment of Gandhian values. On the contrary, Gandhi's death enabled their selective preservation. Reverence replaced resistance. His legacy could be invoked symbolically without being operationally binding. In this sense, death converted Gandhi from a disruptive moral actor into a stabilizing national icon.

Later historical reflections have emphasized the irony of this transformation. Gandhi's posthumous sanctification allowed political leaders to invoke his ideals symbolically without being operationally bound by them - reverence replaced resistance, and death converted a disruptive moral actor into a stabilizing national icon. The militarized spectacle of his funeral, that was so starkly at odds with his rejection of coercive power, symbolized the state's quiet assertion of authority over a moral legacy that could no longer intervene.

d. Moral Loss and Political Gain

The political consequences of Gandhi's death were paradoxical. Morally, the assassination represented a profound violation of the principles Gandhi embodied. Politically, it removed an unresolved ambiguity at the heart of Indian governance: how to reconcile moral absolutism with institutional authority.

With Gandhi gone, the state was better positioned to consolidate secular governance, assert authority over extremist movements, and project stability domestically and internationally. The absence of moral interruption simplified statecraft at a moment when simplicity had tangible value.

Yet this consolidation carried a cost. Gandhi had functioned as a source of moral friction, forcing leaders to confront the ethical implications of their decisions publicly and

immediately. Without him, moral debate narrowed. Ethical conflict was increasingly resolved through law and administration rather than persuasion and conscience. The state grew stronger, but the moral texture of political life thinned.

e. The Counterfactual and Its Limits

To ask what might have happened had Gandhi lived is not to claim certainty. Counterfactual inquiry does not produce answers, but it clarifies tensions. Gandhi's continued presence would likely have prolonged ethical contestation within Indian politics, complicating the state's efforts to centralize authority and normalize governance.

This does not mean that Gandhi's death was necessary, only that it was consequential. His absence enabled a form of governance that his living presence would have persistently unsettled. In this sense, the tragedy occupies an uneasy space in India's history: a moral catastrophe that paradoxically eased the path toward institutional consolidation.

Reframing Gandhi's assassination as a political inflection point does not diminish his significance. It underscores it. Gandhi mattered not only because of what he stood for, but because his presence made governance harder. He forced the state to confront its contradictions openly and continuously.

The question, then, is not whether Gandhi should have lived or died—such a question is both unanswerable and inappropriate. The question is what his absence made possible. In governing without Gandhi, the Indian state gained coherence, authority, and stability. What it lost was a living moral interlocutor who refused to let politics separate itself from ethics.

That tension - between moral leadership and political necessity - was not resolved by Gandhi's death. It was merely displaced. And in that displacement lies one of the enduring dilemmas of the Indian republic.

Chapter 8

The Afterlives of Gandhi's Assassination: Memory, Media, and Political Reappropriation

Gandhi's assassination did not conclude debate over his political role; it inaugurated a long afterlife in which his death has been repeatedly reinterpreted, contested, and redeployed across cultural, political, and generational contexts. While the immediate post-1948 period sought moral closure through mourning, legal judgment, and national canonization, later decades have witnessed a gradual reopening of the event as an object of inquiry rather than reverence alone. This chapter examines how Gandhi's assassination has been re-engaged in modern India through books, films, theater, and public debate, and what these reinterpretations reveal about unresolved tensions surrounding nationalism, pluralism, and political violence.

Rather than treating contemporary representations as distortions of a settled historical truth, this chapter approaches them as indicators of how collective memory evolves in response to changing political anxieties. The persistence of Gandhi-Godse narratives in popular culture suggests that the assassination continues to function as a live political question, not merely a closed moral verdict.

a. From Canonization to Contestation

In the decades following independence, Gandhi's assassination was framed within a tightly managed moral narrative. The state emphasized unity, nonviolence, and national healing, transforming Gandhi into an uncontested symbol of ethical authority. This process of canonization served important stabilizing functions in a fragile republic. It delegitimized

political violence, reinforced constitutionalism, and offered a unifying moral reference point amid the trauma of Partition.

Over time, however, this narrative began to fray. As the immediacy of 1948 receded, later generations encountered Gandhi not as a living moral force but as an institutionalized symbol—present on currency notes, memorials, and official rhetoric, yet increasingly detached from everyday political experience. This distance created space for reassessment. Scholarly and revisionist works increasingly interrogated Gandhi's contradictions and contested political decisions, particularly surrounding Partition and communal politics.

This shift did not represent a wholesale rejection of Gandhi, but a transition from sanctification to interrogation. Gandhi became less a moral endpoint and more a subject of debate, reflecting broader changes in how postcolonial societies reassess founding figures once their immediate legitimizing function has passed.

b. Popular Media and the Reopening of Political Questions

In recent years, Gandhi's assassination has increasingly been revisited through investigative works and popular media that foreground Nathuram Godse's perspective and challenge the long-accepted narrative of a narrowly contained conspiracy. Books such as *The Murderer, the Monarch and the Fakir* by Appu Esthose Suresh and Priyanka Kotamraju argue for wider networks of political complicity, while D.K. Jha's *Gandhi's Assassin: The Making of Nathuram Godse* offers a biographical examination of the ideological formation behind the murder. Popular films such as *The Gandhi Murder* (2019) further reflect this trend by reimagining the assassination through investigative and political lenses (Suresh & Kotamraju, 2021/2022; Jha, 2022; *The Gandhi Murder*, 2019). These works do not occupy a uniform ideological position. Some seek to contextualize Godse's reasoning without endorsing it;

others are openly polemical. What unites them is their challenge to the idea that Gandhi's moral authority, and the meaning of his death, are beyond question.

This trend reflects a broader democratization of historical inquiry, in which audiences outside academic spaces engage with contested pasts through accessible formats. Such representations often provoke anxiety among political and intellectual elites, who fear that revisiting Godse's arguments risks legitimizing violence or undermining foundational values. Yet this anxiety itself reveals how fragile historical consensus can be when it relies on silence rather than sustained engagement.

Importantly, these media interventions do not erase moral distinctions between nonviolence and assassination. Instead, they expose the unresolved nature of the political conflicts that surrounded Gandhi at the end of his life. By dramatizing ideological arguments rather than suppressing them, contemporary media reflects a society grappling with questions that were never fully settled in 1948.

c. Theater, Exposure, and the Limits of Persuasion

The contemporary staging of Mee Nathuram Godse Boltoy exemplifies how Gandhi's assassination has re-entered public discourse as a cultural and generational encounter rather than solely a historical controversy. Once banned on the grounds that it risked legitimizing political violence, the play has since been performed in multiple Indian cities, drawing diverse audiences, including students and younger viewers with little direct connection to the moral atmosphere of the immediate post-independence period. Written by Pradeep Dalvi and first performed in 1997, the play was almost immediately banned by the Maharashtra state government, citing concerns about public order - a decision later overturned by the Bombay High Court in 2001 on the grounds that apprehension of disorder alone cannot justify suppressing expression in a democratic society (Tnn, 2001).

The significance of the play lies not in the positions it advances, but in the questions it reopens. By presenting Godse's reasoning in theatrical form, the performance exposes audiences to the internal logic through which assassination was framed as political necessity, without demanding agreement or moral alignment. The play does not instruct the audience on what to believe; it confronts them with how political violence was justified by its perpetrator.

Crucially, exposure does not equate to persuasion. Cultural performances rarely overturn deeply held political commitments. Rather, they function as prompts for reflection, encouraging audiences to interrogate inherited narratives and reassess assumptions. A single play cannot transform a viewer's ideological commitments, nor can it retroactively alter the moral asymmetry between nonviolent resistance and political murder.

The continued performance of Mee Nathuram Godse Boltoy therefore signals not the normalization of extremist thought, but the persistence of unresolved historical inquiry. Its endurance suggests a public willingness to confront uncomfortable arguments without collapsing into endorsement. In this sense, the play operates as a space for exposure rather than conversion, revealing the limits as well as the possibilities of cultural engagement with politically charged history.

From an analytical standpoint, the play's circulation supports a central claim of this thesis: that Gandhi's assassination remains an open site of political meaning. Cultural interventions do not rewrite history, but they illuminate where historical consensus remains fragile and contested.

d. State Responses, Free Expression, and Moral Boundaries

Official responses to such cultural productions have often framed them as threats to public order and social stability, as seen in government efforts to ban performances such as

Mee Nathuram Godse Boltoy on the grounds that it could provoke unrest. Government statements and institutional critiques have argued that revisiting Godse's arguments risks justifying murder or spreading hatred under the guise of free expression. These concerns are not without basis; political violence gains potency when it is morally rationalized rather than unequivocally condemned.

At the same time, such responses reveal the enduring tension between protecting foundational values and allowing democratic engagement with uncomfortable ideas. Suppression may prevent immediate controversy, but it also reinforces the perception that certain historical questions remain taboo. This instinct to manage political meaning through suppression rather than engagement has precedent in the founding moment itself. In the weeks following Gandhi's assassination, the Indian state banned the RSS, censored publications sympathetic to Hindu nationalist positions, and initiated mass arrests of political opponents - actions examined in Chapter IV as simultaneously legitimate security responses and deliberate ideological boundary-setting. The suppression of the Godse play decades later therefore reflects not an aberration but a structural continuity: the postcolonial Indian state has consistently treated certain political arguments as too dangerous for open circulation, from 1948 to the present. Whether that instinct protects democratic foundations or undermines them remains the central tension this chapter has traced. In a plural democratic society, the attempt to close debate entirely can paradoxically intensify curiosity and polarization.

The challenge, then, is not whether all representations deserve endorsement, but whether democratic societies can tolerate exposure without surrendering moral judgment. The Bombay High Court later lifted the ban, emphasizing that democratic society requires tolerance of diverse viewpoints and that apprehensions of disorder alone cannot justify suppressing expression (Tnn, 2001). The persistence of Gandhi-Godse narratives suggests

that moral authority, when insulated from scrutiny, risks becoming symbolic rather than persuasive.

e. Memory, Reappropriation, and Contemporary Politics

The modern afterlives of Gandhi's assassination are inseparable from contemporary political struggles. Competing ideological movements selectively invoke Gandhi or Godse to legitimize present-day positions on nationalism, secularism, and dissent. Gandhi's image is simultaneously mobilized as a symbol of pluralism and rejected as an obstacle to assertive majoritarian politics. Godse, though universally condemned in law, reappears as a rhetorical device through which grievances about appeasement, sovereignty, and national identity are articulated.

This reappropriation does not imply equivalence between the two figures. Rather, it underscores how unresolved historical events are repeatedly drawn into contemporary political battles. The assassination endures not because its moral meaning is unclear, but because its political implications continue to resonate in debates over who the nation is for, how dissent should be managed, and where the boundaries of legitimate politics lie.

The continued engagement with Gandhi's assassination in modern media, scholarship, and performance reveals that the event has never fully receded into history. Instead, it functions as a recurring site of negotiation through which India confronts enduring tensions between ethics and power, pluralism and majoritarianism, moral authority and political necessity.

These afterlives do not weaken Gandhi's legacy; they testify to its continued relevance. A figure whose death still provokes inquiry, discomfort, and debate remains politically alive. The challenge for contemporary India is not to silence these engagements,

but to approach them with intellectual rigor and moral clarity—recognizing that confronting the arguments behind political violence is not the same as legitimizing it.

In this sense, the persistence of Gandhi-Godse narratives affirms the central argument of this thesis: that Gandhi's assassination was not a historical closure, but a rupture whose consequences continue to shape how India understands nationhood, dissent, and the limits of political action.

Chapter 9

Conclusion

Gandhi's assassination on 30 January 1948 has often been remembered as an ending: the violent interruption of the freedom struggle's moral center and the nation's descent into collective grief. This thesis has argued that it was also a beginning. The killing of Gandhi did not merely remove a leader; it exposed and reshaped the ideological, diplomatic, and political DNA of the Indian republic at the moment of its birth. In place of a singular national tragedy, the assassination emerges here as a strategic rupture—one that accelerated state consolidation, hardened the terms of secular governance, redefined the meaning of national unity, and provided India with an unexpected reservoir of moral authority in the international arena.

Across the chapters, four interrelated claims have been developed. First, Gandhi's death must be read against the ideological conflicts that culminated in his assassination. The final months of Gandhi's life unfolded amid Partition trauma, communal violence, and competing visions of nationhood. Gandhi's insistence on ethical symmetry—especially his public defense of Muslim security and his pressure to honor commitments to Pakistan—came to be reframed by critics as political imbalance and strategic naïveté. This was not merely a disagreement about policy. It was a collision between moral absolutism and an emerging security state, between an inclusive nationalism grounded in conscience and a majoritarian nationalism grounded in sovereignty and demographic primacy. Ambedkar's parallel critique – that Gandhi's vision of Hindu unity obscured caste hierarchy and subordinated Dalit political autonomy to upper-caste interests, underscores that the ideological conflicts culminating in the assassination were not reducible to Hindu-Muslim friction alone. Godse's own arguments, however unacceptable, are analytically valuable precisely because they show

how political grievance can be moralized into certainty, and how moral authority can be reinterpreted as existential threat.

Second, this thesis has shown that the immediate aftermath of the assassination functioned as a formative moment of state-making. Nehru's radio address and the government's swift response—arrests, legal proceedings, and the policing of extremist mobilization—were not only reactions to a crisis but performances of legitimacy by a young state under global scrutiny. The assassination created a moment in which the government could define the ideological boundaries of postcolonial citizenship, delegitimize violent nationalism, and present constitutional authority as both morally grounded and administratively competent. Gandhi's death, paradoxically, enabled a more centralized and technocratic state to consolidate itself under the banner of Gandhian values, even as Gandhi's living presence had often complicated governance through moral intervention outside constitutional mechanisms.

Third, this thesis has argued that Gandhi's assassination carried diplomatic consequences that were not peripheral but constitutive. The international mourning that followed the assassination positioned India, from its earliest days, as the inheritor of a moral legacy disproportionate to its material power. Nehru and India's diplomatic corps drew on Gandhi's symbolic capital to frame nonalignment as ethical autonomy rather than strategic indecision and to present India's voice in the United Nations as principled rather than partisan. Gandhi's absence became a strategic presence: his death offered India a language of moral statecraft at the onset of the Cold War, strengthening its ability to advocate decolonization, restraint, and political independence from great-power blocs.

Fourth, by turning to the contemporary afterlives of the assassination, this thesis has emphasized that the meaning of 1948 remains unsettled. In modern India, Gandhi's death

continues to be revisited through media, scholarship, and performance, including works that foreground Godse's arguments. These cultural recurrences do not erase the moral distinction between nonviolence and assassination. They reveal, instead, the persistence of unresolved political questions about nationalism, pluralism, and the boundaries of legitimate dissent. The continued staging of contested narratives demonstrates that collective memory is not static: it is continuously reworked in response to present anxieties. Exposure, moreover, is not persuasion. Contemporary engagement with difficult material is better understood as a prompt for reflection than as an automatic pathway to ideological conversion.

To trace the political consequences of Gandhi's assassination is not to suggest that those consequences conferred legitimacy upon the violence itself; rather, it reveals how postcolonial governance absorbed a moral catastrophe into the architecture of state power.

Taken together, these findings underscore the thesis's central conclusion: Gandhi's assassination did not simply close an era of anti-colonial struggle; it inaugurated a new era in which national unity, foreign policy, and secular governance were redefined under conditions of violence and vulnerability. The Indian republic was forced, in its earliest months, to decide what it would protect, what it would suppress, and what it would sanctify. Gandhi's death made the state stronger in certain ways—more coherent, more centralized, more capable of projecting stability—but it also removed a living moral interlocutor who refused to let politics separate itself from ethics. The paradox that emerges is not that Gandhi's assassination was politically “useful,” but that it resolved, through catastrophe, a tension that had been structurally embedded in postcolonial state-building: the incompatibility between permanent moral exception and routine institutional governance.

The implications of this argument reach beyond 1948. In contemporary India, debates over nationalism, dissent, and religious identity continue to revolve around competing claims

to moral legitimacy and political necessity. Gandhi's image is invoked to defend pluralism and constitutional restraint; his critics mobilize the language of sovereignty and majoritarian grievance; and the state continues to navigate the unstable boundary between safeguarding public order and narrowing the democratic space for disagreement. The assassination remains relevant because it sits at the intersection of these enduring dilemmas. It is a reminder that political violence is not only an event—it is an argument, and its most dangerous afterlife lies not in the act itself but in the attempts to rationalize it as duty, sacrifice, or corrective justice.

To describe the political consequences of Gandhi's assassination is not to assign it political value. Analytical explanation must not be mistaken for normative endorsement. The consolidation that followed was neither justification nor compensation for the violence that produced it. Rather, it exposes a tragic paradox: that postcolonial governance resolved a structural tension—between moral absolutism and institutional authority—through catastrophe rather than deliberation. Recognizing this paradox deepens, rather than diminishes, the moral gravity of Gandhi's death.

To reinterpret Gandhi's assassination as a political inflection point is not to diminish its moral horror. It is to take the event seriously as a foundational moment in the making of modern India. In that sense, Gandhi's death is not only a story about loss. It is a story about what became possible in the vacuum he left behind—what the state consolidated, what it mythologized, what it avoided, and what it continues to struggle to resolve. The question this thesis leaves us with is therefore not only what Gandhi represented, but what it meant for India to build a republic after losing him—and how that absence continues to shape the country's political imagination today.

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